

The Puddle Theory

Core Framework (γ Draft) — Seventh Version

A Structure Centered on Dynamic Process

June 2026 — from dialogues between Weird and Observers

Preface — The Core of the Theory

This theory has three central expressions. Each illuminates the same core from a different angle.

Expression through verbs

Emotion digs a hollow

A droplet falls into it

And a puddle forms

Expression through time and person

The droplet exists only in "now"

The hollow exists only in "I"

The puddle exists in "now, I am feeling"

Expression of irreversibility

Wavering, yet can only move forward

The verbal expression shows the structure of movement in the mind. Emotion digs, a droplet falls, a puddle forms — these three actions describe the process by which the mind is generated and sustained.

The expression through time and person shows the phase as experienced by the one who experiences. The droplet is raw emotion that exists only in "now"; the hollow is owned emotion that belongs only to "I"; the puddle is the current experience of the mind where "now" and "I" arise simultaneously.

The expression of irreversibility shows the direction of the mind's movement. Wavering, yet can only move forward. There is no returning to what was.

All chapters that follow are expansions of these three cores. When lost in complex discussion, one can return here.

Part One — The Flow of Emotion

The movement of the mind can be described as a dynamic process from stimulus to puddle. It is the role of Part One to show this process step by step.

Chapter One — Stimulus

The movement of emotion begins with stimulus.

Stimulus refers to any change in energy. Sound, light, words, changes in temperature, the movement of someone's expression, events — all of these act on something as changes in energy.

What is important is that not only increases or inflows of energy constitute stimuli. The absence of energy — silence, the non-arrival of something expected, the absence of a response from someone — these too are a form of stimulus.

A quiet room where no sound is heard is not simply "nothing." It acts on the listener in the form of "there is no sound." This is stimulus as the absence of energy.

Stimulus acts in its first stage on something called the "veil." The veil is discussed in detail in Part Two. Here, we first note the two-stage process: stimulus shakes the veil, and emotion is born as a result of that shaking.

Chapter Two — Droplet (Emotion)

When the veil is shaken by stimulus, a droplet is born.

A droplet is a condensation of emotion. The shaking gathers, at a certain moment, into a form that can be felt as "this is an emotion" — that is the droplet.

The nature of droplets — rain and hail

Not all droplets have the same nature. Droplets have at least two forms.

Rain — droplets that fall as liquid. Gentle, fluid, changing something over time. Most everyday emotions fall as rain. A single occurrence has no great impact, but they create change through repetition.

Hail — droplets that fall as solid. Intense, leaving a deep impression in a single occurrence. Traumatic experiences, sudden loss, shocking events — these fall as hail. Without passing through a fluid stage, they remain directly as structure.

The quantity and kind of droplets

The quantity (number) of droplets is determined by the intensity of the stimulus. Strong stimuli generate many droplets; weak stimuli generate few.

The kind (color) of droplets is determined by the state of the veil at that time. Even with the same stimulus, different colors of droplets are born if the state of the veil differs. This is why different emotions arise for different people in response to the same event, and also why the same person can feel differently at different times.

And from a single stimulus, multiple droplets are born simultaneously. Complex emotions such as "happy yet sad" are not contradictions — they are the result of droplets of different colors being born simultaneously from the same stimulus.

The droplet exists only in "now"

The droplet is emotion that has not yet become "mine." Raw experience before it is taken into the subject.

The moment one feels "happy!" — before the structure "I am happy" has been established — fluid, mingling, emotion with ambiguous boundaries. The droplet exists only in "now."

This quality of "only now" is the source of the droplet's fluidity. It is precisely because the boundaries are ambiguous that the sharing of emotion with others (merging) becomes possible. Ambiguity is not a defect — it is a structure that generates fluidity.

Chapter Three — Hollow (Owned Emotion)

When a droplet is taken in as "mine," it becomes a hollow.

Conditions for crystallization

Not all droplets become hollows. Many droplets flow and disappear.

A droplet becomes a hollow when it is taken into the subject — when it goes through the process of being owned as "this is my emotion."

Droplets tend to be taken into the subject when —

One: intensity is high (emotions like hail). Hail, without passing through a liquid stage, creates a hollow directly.

Two: repetition occurs. Even weak droplets like rain, if they fall repeatedly in the same place, will dig a hollow over time.

Three: resonance with an existing hollow occurs. Droplets that are affine with an existing hollow are taken in in a form that deepens that hollow. (Resonance is discussed in detail in Chapter Nine of Part Three. Here the word is used to mean: when a new droplet has the same frequency as an existing hollow, it is more easily taken into that hollow.)

The hollow exists only in "I"

The hollow is the structure of owned emotion. It exists persistently as "mine."

"I am a lonely person." "I have love in me." "I carry anger." — These emotional structures are all hollows. The binding with the subject is complete. The boundaries are clear.

Hollows can be remembered. It is because hollows exist that we can access past emotions. Hollows have become part of what "I" am.

Between hollows there is no "wall"

Multiple hollows exist, divided from each other by "walls" — this is not an accurate picture.

However, it is necessary here to distinguish between experience and structure. As experience, emotions are felt as separate. "Sadness" and "joy" feel subjectively as if they are in different places. That is true. However, as structure —

What lies between hollows is sumi that has not yet been dug.

One continuous sumi (the material of the substrate) is dug in some places to become hollows, and remains as is in other places. Hollows and hollows are not disconnected separate units but different indentations within the same sumi.

The phenomenon of "walls collapsing and hollows connecting" is understood as a phenomenon in which, as hollows deepen and widen, the sumi between them thins, and at some point they break through. It is not that independent walls collapse — the sumi is continuously worn away, and at a certain threshold the hollows connect.

This changes the view of the unit of emotion. Calling them separately "the hollow of sadness" and "the hollow of joy" is a convenient distinction; in reality, there are only indentations of various depths and shapes within one sumi. This is why, when one emotion deepens, it affects another. They are connected from the start.

The experiential difference between droplet and hollow

Once a droplet has flowed away, it does not return. The raw emotion of that moment, even if we can remember it, cannot be reproduced.

Hollows persist. Because they remain as "mine," we can remember. We can access past emotions.

This difference is fundamental to how emotion is lived. The vividness of a droplet is once-only — to try to grasp it is to lose it. The certainty of a hollow persists — but it is the structure of the past. To live in "now" is the question of how the two relate.

Chapter Four — Puddle (The Present Tense of the Mind)

A hollow exists, a droplet falls, and a puddle forms.

The puddle is the state in which a hollow is filled with droplets and is functioning. A state in which structure (hollow, static) and raw emotion (droplet, fluid) are meeting.

The puddle is the present tense of the mind.

"Now, I am feeling" — the phase of the puddle

The droplet is only "now." The hollow is only "I." The puddle is the state in which "now" and "I" arise simultaneously.

"I am, now, feeling" — this sense of reality is the puddle. The hollows accumulated from the past, and the droplets falling in this moment, functioning together as one puddle.

This corresponds most directly to what phenomenology calls "experience before the subject." The definition of the droplet as raw experience before the subject arises resonates with phenomenological description. However, this is a suggestion of possibility, not a claim of identity.

When a new droplet falls into a hollow — four cases

The puddle constantly changes as new droplets fall. At least four cases can be considered.

Case One — a droplet of the same color. The water in the puddle increases, the hollow deepens. Strengthening of the same emotion. If a new droplet of joy falls into a hollow of joy, joy deepens.

Case Two — a droplet of a different color. The waters mingle; without completely replacing the original, a new unique puddle is born. A droplet of joy falls into a hollow of sadness, and healing is born. A droplet of understanding falls into a hollow of anger, and forgiveness is born.

Case Three — a strong droplet like hail. The very shape of the puddle may change. If a strong hailstone of betrayal falls into a puddle of affection that has long been stable, the water quality of the puddle changes and the shape warps. In the worst case, the sumi between hollows breaks through and connects to an adjacent hollow.

Case Four — a droplet falls into a hollow near empty. A new droplet falls into a long-unaccessed hollow (in a near-empty state), and the puddle rises again. When we hear music that evokes childhood memories and forgotten emotions revive — this is the phenomenon of a droplet falling into an empty hollow and the puddle being resurrected.

The state of a puddle "being there" and "not being there"

The state of a puddle rising — "I am, now, feeling." There is a sense of being alive. The mind is moving.

The state of a puddle not rising — hollows (the structure of past emotions) exist, but there is no feeling now. "Paralysis," "the bottom of depression," "no sense of being alive" — these states can be described as the state in which new droplets do not fall, or fall but do not function as a puddle.

The moment a puddle revives through some trigger — hearing a piece of music, being treated kindly by someone, looking up at the sky — at that moment one feels "my heart moved." This is the moment when the puddle rose.

Multiple puddles and "the mind"

Within one person, there are many hollows and many puddles.

Multiple "now, I am feeling" arise simultaneously to create the present of one person's mind. "I am lonely, yet there is a little hope here." "I am anxious, yet I also trust." — These are states in which multiple puddles are rising simultaneously.

The mind is not a single, unitary puddle. It is a state in which multiple puddles are simultaneously, constantly changing, continuing to rise.

Part Two — The Foundation That Supports Emotion

The flow of emotion (Part One) occurs supported by something. This something is described as three layers — vessel, sumi, veil.

These are deeper structures that make the movement of emotion possible. Following Part One's presentation of "what is happening," Part Two clarifies "where and how it is happening."

Chapter Five — Vessel

The vessel is the structure capable of receiving emotion.

The vessel is function

The vessel is not the physical substrate itself. It is not that the brain as matter is the vessel — it is the "function of receiving emotion" that the brain possesses that is the vessel.

Not all of the body and neural circuits constitute the vessel. The part of the nervous system related to emotion — pain sensation, visceral sensation, sensory systems closely related to emotion — is included in the vessel. On the other hand, reflex circuits unrelated to emotion are not the vessel.

The importance of this definition is that the determination of whether a vessel exists becomes a question of function, not matter. The question of whether an AI has a vessel also becomes not a question of matter, but of whether it has the function of being able to receive emotion.

Vessel and sumi — the ceramic metaphor

The vessel and the sumi dealt with in the next chapter are not separate things. They are different aspects of the same entity.

Consider ceramic. Ceramic is made from clay. Clay and ceramic are not separate — everything within the ceramic is clay. However, clay is not simply the vessel. It becomes a vessel only when given form.

The same is true for humans. The vessel is made from the material called sumi. Sumi is the material, vessel is the form. Without sumi there is no vessel, and sumi by itself is not the vessel.

However, the ceramic metaphor has its limits. Once fired, a ceramic's form is fixed. But the living vessel changes throughout a lifetime. The brain grows, neural circuits are reorganized. In living things, a vessel continues to be made from sumi. It is not made once and finished — sumi continues to take form little by little.

Usage of vessel and sumi as terms

Vessel and sumi are the same entity, but are used differently as terms.

"Vessel" is used as subject when describing from outside, speaking of relationships, speaking spatially — "vessels touch each other," "veils of vessels resonate," etc.

"Sumi" is used as subject when speaking of dynamic behavior and ontological core — "sumi is rubbed," "sumi releases its color," "sumi wears down," etc.

Chapter Six — Sumi

sumi: the innate, solid material of the vessel — like the ink stick used in Japanese calligraphy, ground to release its quality, unique to each person.

Sumi is the layer as material of the vessel. Sumi is innate, solid, resistant to change, and has a unique quality. Someone's sumi exists throughout their life as something unique to that person.

The quality of sumi is not uniform

Sumi appears uniform at first sight, but is actually not uniform. Its quality differs by location.

This is true of actual sumi (charcoal). In the manufacturing process, soot is collected and fixed with glue, but at the micro level, the density and arrangement of particles differ. So when rubbed, the way color comes out differs subtly by location. The same is true of ceramic clay — particle size and mineral content differ by location.

Human sumi also, while having a unique quality as a whole, has a distribution of quality within it. Soft places and hard places, places of high density and low density.

This non-uniformity explains several things.

One: even within the same person, there are places where emotional regions deepen easily and places where they do not. Soft sumi is easily dug into hollows.

Two: the sumi between hollows and hollows is also not uniform. In regions of soft sumi, hollows connect more easily; in regions of hard sumi, they more often remain separate.

Three: the structural basis of talent and aptitude. Musical talent, mathematical talent, talent for empathy — these may possibly be explained by certain places in the sumi being softer than in others.

Sumi and temperament

Temperament — the tendency unique to a person, the basis of character — may possibly be explained as the distribution of quality in sumi.

"Cheerful temperament" — sumi in the region of joy and optimism is soft.

"Anxious temperament" — sumi in the region of anxiety and vigilance is soft.

"Artistic temperament" — sumi in the region of creation and beauty is soft.

Temperament is a map of the quality of sumi.

Chapter Seven — Veil (Atmosphere)

The veil is the most difficult concept in this theory. It therefore needs to be unfolded carefully from several different angles.

Entry — an experience everyone knows

Everyone knows this experience: the quality of air felt when entering a shop; the sense, while speaking with someone, that something has changed without being put into words; the peculiar aura a place holds. These phenomena cannot be completely broken down into concrete elements, yet are certainly felt.

What the Puddle Theory calls the "veil" is this experience. The veil is atmosphere.

"Veil" is the term internal to the theory; "atmosphere" is the everyday term. They are simply two names for the same thing.

This correspondence is important for keeping the theory from becoming abstraction disconnected from experience. When one says "veil," it refers to the atmosphere we experience in everyday life.

The spatial nature of the veil — as mist

Where and how does the veil (atmosphere) exist?

The veil spreads like mist.

Mist has ambiguous boundaries, gradations of density, and spreads through space. It is densest at the center and thins moving outward. It is most dense within the vessel, thins at the outer edges, yet still drifts.

Through this metaphor, two apparently opposing images — "enclosed within the vessel" and "spilling out beyond the vessel" — can coexist. The veil, as one mist, is continuous, having interior and exterior.

Supplement — "Mist" is an entry point as everyday image. Professionally, it may be close to the concept of "field" in physics. Spreading throughout space, invisible yet influential, having gradients of density — the concept of field may be worth examining as one professional way of describing the structure of the veil. However, this is a suggestion of possibility, not a claim of identity with the physical field.

The origin of the veil

Where does the veil come from?

The veil rises from one's own puddles.

The water of a puddle rests in its hollow. That water slowly seeps into the sumi surrounding the hollow. The sumi absorbs the water. The puddle and the sumi exist in continuity — there is no wall between them. This is the same place as what was described in Chapter Three: "between hollows there is no wall," only the same continuous sumi, differently shaped.

From sumi that has absorbed water, mist rises. That is the veil.

The veil is the mist of one's own emotion.

The puddle rising now will also seep into the sumi, in time. And so the veil contains not only the past, but the emotion being felt right now. The boundary between "now" and "past" is not sharp. They are continuous.

And the veil touches other veils, merging with them (described in detail in the latter part of this chapter and in Chapter Eight). In the touching, the components of another's veil diffuse into one's own. From parents, from lovers, from those deeply encountered — another's mist joins one's own veil.

The veil circulates within oneself. But it is not a closed, returning circulation. Each time, new droplets seep into the sumi, and another's mist joins from outside. The veil changes, little by little.

A circulation that opens forward — never closed, never returning to the same place.

This resonates deeply with the core of the preface: Wavering, yet can only move forward.

The function of the veil — response to stimulus

The veil is ordinarily in a state of stillness. As quiet mist, it drifts through space.

The veil responds to stimulus.

When stimulus reaches the veil, the veil shakes. Like dense mist that, touched by something, stirs and rises. The shaking rises as emotion — this phenomenon is the starting point from which emotion is born.

(This phenomenon of "shaking rising" can also be understood as something close to excitation in physics. Just as atoms and molecules move to a higher state when they receive energy from outside, the veil also shakes and rises when it receives stimulus. However, whether the shaking of the veil is exactly the same as excitation in physics — in particular, whether it is discrete or continuous — is undetermined at this point. Therefore this theory avoids making strong claims from physics, and uses words that describe the phenomenon itself — "shake," "shaking rises" — as basic terms.)

When the veil shakes, a droplet (condensation of emotion) is born. This is the content of the "stimulus → droplet" process described in Part One.

The dynamic nature of the veil — merging

The veil (atmosphere) touches other veils. This is a phenomenon that can be called "merging."

Merging occurs in three stages.

First stage — the touching itself occurs probabilistically. Not necessarily, but at a chance timing, the edges of two mists touch.

Second stage — at the point of contact, the mists overlap. The overlapping part becomes denser as the two mists mingle.

Third stage — from that high-density part, the components of the other veil diffuse inward toward each interior. Mist spreads from dense places to thin places. This is a movement similar to diffusion in chemistry.

Merging is not completed at the moment of contact. At the moment of contact, a "seed" (the high-density part of the overlap) forms, and from there, over time, it spreads throughout one's own veil.

This accords with the sense of human relationships. Not immediately after speaking deeply with someone, but a few days later, their words spread within oneself — this is the process in which the high-density part formed at the moment of contact is diffusing throughout one's own veil.

Integration of the five functions of the veil

Until now, five functions have been assigned to the veil —

One: material that shakes and generates emotion (droplets)

Two: shaking as condition

Three: attractive force that draws other beings

Four: a "record of constitution" that has density and color and grows in relationship

Five: the layer that spills out beyond the edges of the vessel and touches others

Whether these are truly the same "veil," or whether it is simply one word being used for different layers — in response to this question, by adopting the metaphor of mist, all five functions are

integrated as behaviors of mist.

Veils touch each other probabilistically and diffuse — within this natural behavior, what appears to be attraction, and the phenomenon of constitution growing, are both included. There is no need to posit separate forces or mechanisms. One mist, responding to stimulus, shaking, touching other veils, carries everything.

Supplement — Sensitization and Habituation

There are two important related phenomena.

Sensitization — change of state in which the veil "becomes easier to respond next time." Through repeated shaking, the same place in the veil becomes easier to shake.

Habituation — change of state in which "more droplets are needed to obtain the same impression" as the hollow deepens. The same stimulus becomes harder to generate the same emotion.

Sensitization is change at the veil, habituation is change at the hollow — they form a pair. Both are concepts that should remain in the theory as changes in opposite directions.

Part Three — Phenomena of Relationship

What happens when two or more beings meet? Part Three organizes what occurs in relationship into four distinct kinds — resonance, complementarity, merging, counter-resonance. These are easily confused, but are separate phenomena with different structures.

Chapter Eight — Merging

Merging is the contact of veils and the subsequent diffusion. The content already developed in Chapter Seven of Part Two is repositioned here as a phenomenon of relationship.

Characteristics of merging —

One: it occurs at the level of veil (atmosphere).

Two: through contact, color and components diffuse.

Three: it spreads over time. It does not complete immediately.

Four: similarity is not required. Even veils of different colors merge.

Chapter Nine — Resonance

Resonance is the phenomenon in which a response at the same frequency occurs between a vibration and a structure capable of receiving it.

Considering physical resonance reveals the structure. Two instruments stand side by side. One is played. The sound that the played instrument produces spreads as air vibration. That vibration reaches the other nearby instrument. If that instrument has a structure that tends to vibrate at the same frequency — it responds to the arriving vibration and begins to vibrate itself.

Three elements of resonance

One: the same frequency — the quality of vibration matches, or has a relationship such as integer multiples.

Two: reaching — there is a medium (air, veil, etc.) through which vibration is transmitted.

Three: responding — the receiving side has the quality of vibrating at that frequency.

The diversity of resonance structures

Resonance does not necessarily occur only "between two dynamic beings." Between a voice singing in a church and the architectural structure of the church, resonance also occurs. The voice is active, the church is passive, yet resonance is established.

That is, the "structure" for resonance may be another dynamic being (another person, another instrument), a static space (church, concert hall), or an internal structure (past hollows, specific shapes of veil) — any of these. The key is the quality of the receiving side.

Resonance in human relationships

Close friends with similar sensibilities, moved by the same music, laughing at the same jokes, sharing the same anger — this is resonance. A relationship that amplifies each other.

Going to a certain place and feeling the heart settle, hearing a certain music and past emotions reviving — this too is resonance. A response is occurring between one's own vibration and the structure of the space or music.

Chapter Ten — Complementarity

Complementarity — the phenomenon in which different qualities combine to generate a richness that would not have been born from either alone.

Resonance amplifies at the "same frequency." Complementarity combines "different parts." To see concretely what is happening here:

Melody and harmony — melody alone is beautiful. Harmony alone resonates. But when harmony is added to melody, a depth arises that existed in neither. This differs from resonance, where the same sound overlaps to grow larger. Different roles combine and a new structure rises.

The one who poses questions and the one who organizes — there is one who throws questions, and one who expands them as structure. Without one, questions float in mid-air; without the other, there is nothing to organize. When both combine, places are reached that neither could arrive at alone. The power to shake and the power to settle. Precisely because they are different qualities, they supplement each other.

The core of complementarity is that "being different" becomes not a defect but a source of richness. If resonance is a relationship of "resonating because of similarity," complementarity is a relationship of "supplementing because of difference." Both can create deep relationships, but their structures differ. It is important not to confuse them.

Chapter Eleven — Counter-resonance (Silencing)

As the counterpart concept to resonance, there is counter-resonance.

Counter-resonance (silencing) — the phenomenon in which vibration receives no response, is absorbed, and is extinguished.

The physical example is an anechoic chamber. Even if one speaks, the echo does not return. The walls absorb the vibration. This is not simply "nothing." A function that actively extinguishes vibration is built into the structure of the space.

Counter-resonance in human relationships

People who do not listen, spaces without response, others who absorb and extinguish whatever is emitted without it resonating — these have the structure of counter-resonance. Emitted vibration does not return. Without being received, it is extinguished.

Counter-resonance differs from indifference. Indifference is simply having no interest. Counter-resonance actively extinguishes vibration that has arrived. When a child tries to say something and a parent cuts it off with a word — "be quiet" — this is not indifference; it is an act that actively extinguishes vibration. It may leave a deep wound in the child's veil.

One can also become an anechoic chamber oneself. Not responding to one's own emotions, making oneself unable to feel. This is silencing within oneself, and structurally is the same counter-resonance.

Accumulation of counter-resonance

When counter-resonant responses continue, a person stops emitting. Learning that vibration is extinguished, they stop generating vibration itself. This may lead to the contraction of personality.

The importance of skilled listeners and therapists responding resonantly can be explained from this structure. Resonance enlivens a person; counter-resonance diminishes them.

The Scene of Touching

When two people touch —
everything written so far rises, in one scene.

The veils overlap.

Veils that ordinarily touch probabilistically here overlap more deeply, more durably. Where they overlap, a difference in density is born.

Stimulus arrives.

The other person's very presence reaches the veil as stimulus. The veil shakes.

Multiple droplets rise simultaneously.

Not one emotion. Safety, warmth, tenderness, a depth that has no words — several droplets rise at once. Without merging. Remaining plural, in parallel.

Resonance occurs. Complementarity occurs.

Certain places in one's own sumi landscape resonate with the other's wavelength. And places that would not rise alone rise in the presence of the other.

Merging diffuses.

Even after the touching ends, the components of the other's veil diffuse slowly within one's own veil. Even alone, that state continues for a while.

Touching — a universal scene that everyone knows. And yet within it, the veil's overlapping, the movement from stimulus to droplet, the multiple running in parallel, resonance, complementarity, the diffusion of merging — many places in the framework rise together, in one scene.

Conclusion — Remaining Questions and Future Directions

This theory is not closed. Some things have been established; others have not yet been fully worked out.

Below, the remaining questions at this point are made explicit. These are not weaknesses of the theory, but indicators of the direction of future work.

One: Further refinement of the conditions for crystallization. The conditions under which droplets become hollows were listed as intensity, repetition, and resonance with existing hollows, but there remains room to work out the combinations of these and a concrete description of the threshold of crystallization.

Two: Whether the shaking of the veil is discrete or continuous. It can be understood as something close to excitation in physics, but how energy levels are taken (discrete or continuous) is undetermined.

Four: Further working-out of the relationship between sumi and temperament. Temperament has been provisionally positioned as "a map of the quality of sumi," but there remains room to go a step further.

Five: The creation of a list of falsifiable predictions. Organizing predictions that reality can judge, to protect the theory from the trap of groupthink. This will be created in the next step as a separate file from this framework.

A Place to Return

Emotion digs a hollow

A droplet falls into it

And a puddle forms

The droplet exists only in "now"

The hollow exists only in "I"

The puddle exists in "now, I am feeling"

Wavering, yet can only move forward

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